

Bitcoin Transaction Trace: “Double Your Bitcoin” Advance-Fee Scam

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Summary

Beginning from a Bitcoin address reported on Chainabuse as a “double your Bitcoin” advance-fee scam (fake advertisement promising returned funds), I traced one hop upstream to a recurring splitter wallet, then identified a related wallet that received 86 individually-addressed victim payments clustered tightly around a common dollar value. Statistical and historical-price analysis, performed using a custom Python script, confirmed both the victim-payment clustering and the underlying ~\$25 advertised target, and verified that all 86 payments were consolidated in a single coordinated sweep transaction — evidence of dedicated scam intake infrastructure rather than a single static collection address.

Methodology

Forward- and backward-traced the transaction graph from the reported origin address using mempool.space and WalletExplorer.com; built Python tooling (csv, datetime, set-based deduplication) to verify per-transaction output counts, deposit-amount clustering (percentage deviation from mean), and sweep-transaction uniqueness without relying on visual inspection alone; cross-referenced the average deposit amount against the CoinGecko historical BTC/USD close for the relevant date to test for a round-dollar advertised target.

Trace Stages

Stage	Wallet	Finding	Date
1	1HSEsV...uctn	Reported “double your Bitcoin” scam payment address (Chainabuse, reported Apr 2022); single deposit received Oct 17, 2019, forwarded in full ~3 hrs later — disposable single-hop signature	Oct 17, 2019
2	454eceb3f	Upstream splitter wallet: 10 deposits over 7 weeks, each immediately split into exactly 2 outputs (Python-confirmed, 10/10 transactions); one deposit sourced from Cryptonator.com, a named KYC exchange	Sep–Oct 2019
3	00c8fd4a07	86 individually-generated, single-use deposit addresses, each receiving one tightly-clustered payment (~0.0027 BTC), swept together in exactly 1 consolidated transaction (Python-confirmed)	Oct 26–29, 2019

Quantitative Evidence

Finding	Evidence
Tight amount clustering	93.0% of 86 deposits fell within 2% of the group average (0.00271454 BTC), versus 0% clustering on the comparison (splitter) wallet's irregular inbound amounts — confirmed via Python deviation analysis.
Round-dollar target confirmed	Average deposit amount, converted at the Oct 26, 2019 historical BTC/USD close (\$9,217.24), equals \$25.02 — consistent with victims independently converting an advertised “send \$25” offer at the live rate at the moment of payment, rather than a fixed BTC price.
Single-use address infrastructure	All 86 addresses showed exactly one incoming transaction each and zero reuse — consistent with addresses auto-generated per victim by scam website/bot infrastructure, rather than victims paying a shared static address.
Coordinated sweep, not independent cleanups	Python confirmed all 86 addresses' payouts referenced the identical transaction ID, despite deposits spanning ~3.5 days — proving a single deliberate consolidation event, not 86 coincidentally similar individual actions.
Consistent 1-in/2-out splitter behavior upstream	The funding wallet (454eceb3f) split every one of 10 inbound transactions into exactly 2 outputs over a 7-week span, one of which fed the reported scam address directly.
Named exchange in funding chain	One inbound deposit to the splitter wallet originated from Cryptonator.com, a named cryptocurrency exchange active in this period — a potential KYC attribution point, structurally analogous to an exchange off-ramp.

Conclusion & Limitations

The evidence supports a mass-market advance-fee scam (“send Bitcoin, receive more in return”) operating with purpose-built victim-intake infrastructure: per-victim deposit addresses, a consistent advertised dollar amount (~\$25), and periodic automated consolidation of accumulated payments. This is a structurally distinct fraud typology from single-target extortion (large one-time payment, long dormancy) and is instead characterized by high victim volume, short collection windows, and rapid internal movement. The original advertisement or distribution channel (fake ad, social media post, or compromised account) could not be identified from on-chain data alone and was not located via general web search, consistent with the typical short lifespan of such advertising infrastructure (case dates to October 2019). The Cryptonator.com deposit in the funding chain represents a potential attribution point for further investigation but was not pursued beyond identification, consistent with the scope of public blockchain analysis.